Kabaddi and Traditional Indian Sports

Introduction to Kabaddi

Kabaddi is a contact team sport that originated in ancient India and is played in many parts of South Asia. It needs no equipment, only strength, speed, agility, breath control and teamwork. The word "kabaddi" is believed to come from the Tamil word "kai-pidi", meaning "holding hands", or from the Hindi word for "holding breath", since players chant it continuously during a raid. The game has been played for thousands of years in villages, and is mentioned in the Mahabharata, in which Abhimanyu was trapped in the Chakravyuha formation. It is called "Sadugudu" in Tamil Nadu, "Hu-tu-tu" in western India, "Chedu-gudu" in Telugu areas and "Hadudu" in Bangladesh. Kabaddi is the state game of Tamil Nadu, and is the national game of Bangladesh. Modern rules were standardised in the 1920s and 1930s, in Maharashtra, and the Amateur Kabaddi Federation of India was formed in 1973. Kabaddi was demonstrated at the 1936 Berlin Olympics, was introduced at the Asian Games in 1990 in Beijing, and has had a world cup since 2004.

How Many Players Are in a Kabaddi Team?

A kabaddi team has 12 players in the squad, but only 7 players are on the court at one time, with 5 substitutes on the bench. Two teams of seven face each other, each in their own half of the court. The court for men measures about 13 metres by 10 metres, divided by a midline into two halves, with baulk lines and bonus lines, and the women's court is slightly smaller, at 11 by 8 metres. A match has two halves of 20 minutes each, with a 5-minute break between them, and the teams change sides. Players are divided into weight classes in amateur competitions. A referee, umpires, scorers and a TV official supervise the game.

What Is a Raid?

A raid is the attacking move in kabaddi. Teams take turns sending one player, called the raider, into the opponent's half to try to score points. The raider must continuously chant "kabaddi, kabaddi" in a single breath, which proves that they are not taking another breath, and must not take a second breath. Within 30 seconds, the raider tries to touch one or more of the defenders (called antis) with a hand or foot and return to their own half before being tackled, without losing breath. Each defender touched is out, and the raider's team earns one point for each. The defenders try to stop the raider by tackling or holding them so that they cannot return to their half; if the raider is caught, the defending team scores a point. A raider who crosses the bonus line, with at least six defenders on the mat, can earn a bonus point. When a player is put out, they go to the bench, and when a team scores, its players who were out come back in, one for each point. If a team puts the opposing team out entirely, it scores an "all out" and earns two additional points. A "super raid" is when a raider scores three or more points in one raid, and a "super tackle" is made when defenders are three or fewer. A "do-or-die raid" occurs on the third consecutive empty raid of a team, where the raider has to score or is declared out. If the raider fails to return or does not chant, the raid is declared invalid.

Pro Kabaddi League and Achievements

The Pro Kabaddi League (PKL), launched in July 2014, turned kabaddi into a major spectator sport with franchises, TV coverage and professional players. It has 12 teams, such as the Tamil Thalaivas from Chennai, Patna Pirates, Jaipur Pink Panthers, Bengaluru Bulls, U Mumba and Puneri Paltan. India's men's team won gold at every Asian Games from 1990 to 2014, with seven successive golds, a record, and won the Kabaddi World Cup in 2004, 2007 and 2016. India won the gold again at the 2022 Asian Games in Hangzhou, after a bronze in 2018, with the women's team also winning gold in 2010, 2014 and 2022. Famous players include Anup Kumar, Rahul Chaudhari, Pardeep Narwal, Ajay Thakur, Pawan Sehrawat and Naveen Kumar.

Name Two Other Traditional Indian Sports

Two other traditional Indian sports are kho-kho and mallakhamb. Kho-kho is a tag game in which nine players of the chasing team sit in a line, with alternating players facing opposite directions, while three of the opposite team try to avoid being touched. The chasers call "kho" to give the turn to another chaser. India's men and women teams won the first Kho Kho World Cup in New Delhi in January 2025. Mallakhamb is a Maharashtrian sport in which gymnasts perform feats and yoga poses on a vertical wooden pole or a rope, and it is the state sport of Madhya Pradesh. Other traditional sports include gilli-danda, a game with a stick and a small piece of wood, similar to a game of cricket and baseball; kalaripayattu, an ancient martial art of Kerala; silambam, the traditional stick-fighting martial art of Tamil Nadu, which dates back to the Sangam age, and was a popular skill taught by gurus; Pehlwani or kushti, the Indian form of wrestling; lagori, also known as seven stones, a ball-and-stones game; gatka, a Sikh martial art with sticks and swords; Thang-ta of Manipur; Sagol Kangjei, the Manipuri precursor of modern polo; Kambala, the buffalo race of Karnataka; vallam kali, the snake boat race of Kerala; and Jallikattu, the bull-taming of Tamil Nadu. Traditional board games like Pallanguzhi and Chaturanga, and children's games such as kancha (marbles), pambaram (spinning tops), and kite flying are also well-loved. Many Tamil village games, such as ilavattam, kittipul and uriyadi, are played at festivals.

Promotion of Indigenous Sports

The Khelo India programme, launched in 2018, supports traditional sports, and the Khelo India Games have included kabaddi, kho-kho, mallakhamb, kalaripayattu and gatka. Tamil Nadu has introduced the Chief Minister's Trophy for sports, and the state organises village sports events. Silambam was given recognition as a sport in India in recent years.

Challenges and Future

Challenges include lack of infrastructure, the growth of modern sports, and injuries. The popularity of PKL and the Kho Kho World Cup show that traditional sports can succeed commercially, and may be included in future multi-sport events.

Quick Facts

- A kabaddi team has 12 players, with 7 on the court at a time.
- A raid is when one raider enters the opponent's half, chanting "kabaddi", to touch defenders and return within 30 seconds without being tackled.
- Kabaddi is the state game of Tamil Nadu, where it is called Sadugudu.
- Two other traditional sports are kho-kho and mallakhamb; others include silambam, gilli-danda and kalaripayattu.
- The Pro Kabaddi League started in July 2014; the Tamil Thalaivas represent Chennai.